nucleic acid is present as a single unit but in wound tumour virus and in influenza virus it is found in segments. The viruses possessing DNA are called **'Deoxyviruses'** whereas those possessing RNA are called **'Riboviruses'**. Majority of animal and bacterial viruses are DNA viruses (HIV is the animal virus which possess RNA). Plant viruses generally contain RNA (Cauliflower Mosaic virus possess DNA). The nucleic acids may be single stranded or double stranded. On the basis of nature of nucleic acid viruses are classified into four Categories. They are Viruses with ssDNA (Parvo viruses), dsDNA (Bacteriophages), ssRNA (TMV)and dsRNA(Wound Tumour Virus).

Table 1.2: Different Classes of viruses

Class	Example
Class 1 – Viruses with dsDNA	Adeno viruses
Class 2 –Viruses with (+) sense ssDNA	Parvo viruses
Class 3 – Viruses with dsRNA	Reo viruses
Class 4 – Viruses with (+)sense ssRNA	Toga viruses
Class 5 – Viruses with (−)sense ssRNA	Rhabdo viruses
Class 6 – Viruses with (+) sense ssRNA –RT: that replicate with DNA intermediate in life cycle	Retro viruses
Class 7 – Viruses with ds DNA –RT: that replicate with RNA intermediate in life cycle	Hepadna viruses

1.2.5 Tobacco Mosaic Virus (TMV)

Tobacco mosaic virus was discovered in 1892 by Dimitry Ivanowsky from the Tobacco plant. Viruses infect healthy plants through vectors like aphids, locusts etc. The first visible symptom of TMV is discoloration of leaf colour along the veins and show typical yellow and green mottling which is the mosaic symptom. The downward curling and distortion of young apical leaves occurs, plant becomes stunted and yield is affected.

Structure

Electron microscopic studies have revealed that TMV is a rod shaped (Figure 1.4b) helical virus measuring about 300x20nm with a molecular weight of $39x10^6$ Daltons. The virion is made up of two constituents, a protein coat called **capsid** and a core called **nucleic acid**. The protein coat is made up of approximately 2130 identical protein subunits called **capsomeres** which are present around a central single stranded RNA molecule. The genetic information necessary for the formation of a complete TMV particle is contained in its RNA. The RNA consists of 6,500 nucleotides.

1.2.6 Bacteriophage

Viruses infecting bacteria are called **Bacteriophages**. It literally means 'eaters of bacteria' (Gr: Phagein = to eat). Phages are abundant in soil, sewage water, fruits, vegetables, and milk.

Structure of T_4 bacteriophage

The T_4 phage is tadpole shaped and consists of head, collar, tail, base plate and fibres (Figure 1.4). The head is hexagonal which consists of about 2000 identical protein subunits. The long helical tail consists of an inner tubular core which is connected to the head by a collar. There is a base plate attached to the end of tail. The base plate contains six spikes and tail fibres. These fibres are used to attach the phage on the cell wall of bacterial host during replication. A dsDNA molecule of about 50 µm is tightly packed inside the head. The DNA is about 1000 times longer than the phage itself.

1.2.7 Multiplication or Life Cycle of Phages

Phages multiply through two different types of life cycle. a. Lytic or Virulent cycle b. Lysogenic or Avirulent life cycle.

a. Lytic Cycle

During lytic cycle of phage, disintegration of host bacterial cell occurs and the progeny virions are released (Figure 1.5a). The steps involved in the lytic cycle are as follows:

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